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Bias in Cable News: Persuasion and Polarization

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1 Big picture

Question. How much does slanted cable news change voting behavior, how strong are viewers' tastes for like-minded news, and can these forces help explain political polarization?

Setting. The paper studies U.S. cable news from the late 1990s through 2008, focusing on CNN, Fox News Channel (FNC), and MSNBC. The key outcomes are cable news viewership, presidential vote choice, and ideology.

Core challenge. Viewership of slanted news is highly endogenous. Conservatives may watch Fox News because they are already conservative; liberals may watch MSNBC because they are already liberal. A simple correlation between viewing and voting therefore mixes persuasion with selection.

Key empirical idea. The paper uses the local cable channel position of a news channel as an instrument for viewership. A lower numerical channel position makes a channel easier to encounter and therefore increases viewing, but the identifying assumption is that the historical assignment of channel positions is not chosen to match local political preferences.

Main reduced-form and IV result. A one-standard-deviation decrease in Fox News channel position increases Fox News viewing by about 2.5 minutes per week. The corresponding increase in induced Fox News viewing raises Republican presidential vote share by about 0.3 percentage points among compliers.

Main structural contribution. The paper estimates a model in which voters choose how much news to watch, prefer ideologically closer news, and have their own ideology pulled toward the ideology of the channels they watch. The model separates two forces:

- **taste for like-minded news:** viewers prefer outlets closer to their initial ideology;
- **persuasive influence:** watching slanted news moves viewers' ideology toward the channel.

Main counterfactual result. Removing Fox News from cable lineups would reduce the Republican presidential vote share by about 0.46 percentage points in 2000, 3.59 percentage points in 2004, and 6.34 percentage points in 2008. The growth over time comes from greater Fox News viewership and increasingly conservative Fox News slant.

Polarization result. Cable news can generate a modest but meaningful increase in ideological polarization. The model's increase in public polarization is comparable to the observed increase in some survey-based measures, though much smaller than the rise in polarization among elected officials.

Media-power result. The model implies that concentrated control of cable news channels could have large electoral influence. However, maximizing vote-share influence and maximizing viewership are not the same objective. Fox News's observed slant is much closer to its Republican vote-share-maximizing slant than to its ratings-maximizing slant.

Economic takeaway. The paper is important because it combines a credible source of viewership variation with a structural model of media choice and persuasion. It shows that slanted media is not only consumed by partisans; it can also move some voters and amplify polarization through feedback between persuasion and selective exposure.

2 Data and measurement: key objects

2.1 Institutional setting

During the sample period, households could receive television through local cable systems, national satellite providers, or over-the-air broadcast signals. Cable systems had local lineups, while satellite providers used national lineups.

Interpretation. This institutional feature is essential. Local cable channel positions vary across cable systems, whereas satellite subscribers in the same zip code face a different national lineup. This makes satellite viewership a useful placebo group.

2.2 Channel positions

The key instrument is the ordinal channel position of a cable news channel on the local cable lineup. For example, Fox News at channel 25 is treated as easier to encounter than Fox News at channel 65.

Interpretation. Channel position matters because viewers often browse sequentially or begin search near familiar low-numbered channels. Lower positions are historically associated with higher viewership.

2.3 Cable lineup data

The paper uses Nielsen FOCUS data on cable systems by year. The data record whether CNN, FNC, and MSNBC are available on each cable system, their channel positions, and the zip codes served by the system.

Key facts. CNN was nearly universally available by 1998. FNC and MSNBC entered in the mid-1990s and expanded quickly, reaching most cable subscribers by the early 2000s.

Interpretation. Availability variation is useful for comparison with earlier work, but later in the sample most systems carry the channels, so channel position becomes the more important source of variation.

2.4 Viewership data

The paper uses two main viewership sources.

Zip-level Nielsen viewership. Nielsen Local TV data measure ratings for CNN, FNC, and MSNBC by zip code for 2005–2008. The authors convert ratings into average minutes or hours watched per week.

Individual-level Mediamark and Simmons data. These commercial survey data report individual cable news viewing, subscription type, demographics, and zip code. Mediamark covers 2000–2007; Simmons is used for 2008.

Interpretation. Zip-level Nielsen data provide the strongest first-stage evidence. Individual data help estimate heterogeneous viewing patterns and match the structural model.

2.5 Voting data

The paper uses both aggregate and individual voting data.

Zip-level 2008 voting. Precinct-level presidential election returns are aggregated to zip codes to compute two-party Republican vote share.

Individual vote intention. The National Annenberg Election Study and Cooperative Congressional Election Study provide survey measures of presidential vote intention and demographics.

County-level pre-treatment voting. County-level Republican presidential vote share in 1996 is used as a pre-Fox political control and placebo outcome.

Interpretation. The zip-level voting data are the main second-stage outcome. The 1996 outcomes are important because they predate the expansion of Fox News and can test whether channel positions are correlated with preexisting Republican areas.

2.6 Demographics and political controls

The paper controls for rich local demographic characteristics from the Census and other sources. These include age, race, income, education, urban/rural status, homeownership, housing values, veterans, family structure, religious composition, 1996 Republican vote share, and 1996 Republican campaign contribution share.

Interpretation. Rich controls reduce the concern that channel position is merely proxying for local political demand or residential sorting.

2.7 Text-based ideology measures

The paper measures channel ideology using broadcast transcripts and Congressional Record text. The method follows the logic of Groseclose–Milyo and Gentzkow–Shapiro:

- identify phrases used by members of Congress;
- relate phrase usage to congressional ideology measured by DW-NOMINATE scores;
- use the estimated phrase-ideology relationship to predict the ideology of each cable news channel in each year.

Interpretation. This gives a time-varying measure of channel slant. Fox News is consistently to the right of CNN and MSNBC. MSNBC tracks CNN early in the sample and moves left after its format switch around 2006.

2.8 Main dependent variables

Viewership. Average minutes or hours per week spent watching CNN, FNC, and MSNBC.

Voting. Republican presidential vote share at the zip-code level or individual intention to vote Republican.

Ideology. A latent one-dimensional ideology in the structural model, initialized from county and demographic information and then updated through exposure to slanted cable news.

2.9 Descriptive facts

Several descriptive facts motivate the analysis:

- Lower channel positions are associated with higher viewership.

- Fox News becomes more widely available and more conservative over time.
- MSNBC becomes more liberal after the mid-2000s format change.
- Cable news audiences are not perfectly segregated by ideology; many viewers consume outlets that are not exactly aligned with their party.
- Fox News has substantially larger viewership than MSNBC during the main sample period.

3 Models and empirical specifications: all equations plus interpretation

3.1 First stage: viewership and channel position

For news channel c , the first-stage equation is

$$h_{zct} = \delta_{ct} + a_{zct} + \alpha_c x_{zt} + \zeta_{c,\text{FNC}} p_{zt}^{\text{FNC}} + \zeta_{c,\text{MSNBC}} p_{zt}^{\text{MSNBC}} + \varepsilon_{zct}^H. \quad (1)$$

Objects.

- h_{zct} is average minutes watched per week of channel c in zip code z and year t .
- p_{zt}^{FNC} and p_{zt}^{MSNBC} are local cable positions of FNC and MSNBC.
- a_{zct} are availability indicators for the news channels.
- x_{zt} are local demographics and cable-system controls.
- δ_{ct} are channel-year, state-year, or county-year fixed effects depending on the specification.

Interpretation. The first stage asks whether a lower channel position predicts more viewing, holding constant geography, year, channel availability, cable-system controls, and demographics. The key coefficient is negative: a higher numerical position means lower viewership.

3.2 Reduced form: channel position and Republican vote share

The zip-level reduced form is

$$y_z = \gamma_g + a_z + \beta x_z + \zeta_{\text{FNC}} p_z^{\text{FNC}} + \zeta_{\text{MSNBC}} p_z^{\text{MSNBC}} + \varepsilon_z^R, \quad (2)$$

where y_z is the Republican presidential vote share in zip code z .

Interpretation. This equation asks whether places where Fox News is assigned a lower channel position also vote more Republican, after controls. The reduced form captures the total effect of channel position on voting through all channels, primarily through induced Fox News viewing.

3.3 Second stage: voting and predicted Fox News viewership

The second-stage specification is

$$y_z = \gamma_g + a_z + \beta x_z + \zeta_{\text{MSNBC}} p_z^{\text{MSNBC}} + \rho_f \hat{h}_z^f + \varepsilon_z^V, \quad (3)$$

where $\hat{h}_z^f$ is predicted Fox News viewing from the first stage.

Interpretation. The coefficient ρ_f is the IV estimate of the effect of Fox News viewing on Republican vote share. It is a local average treatment effect for viewers whose Fox News consumption is shifted by channel position.

Two-sample feature. The first stage uses viewership data, while the second stage uses voting data. The paper uses bootstrap methods appropriate for two-sample IV and clusters by cable system.

3.4 Satellite placebo specification

The satellite placebo compares cable subscribers and satellite subscribers in the same zip code. Satellite viewers live in the same local area but do not face the local cable lineup.

Logic. If Fox News channel position is simply proxying for local unobserved Republican taste, then it should also predict Fox News viewing among satellite subscribers in the same zip code. The paper finds that it does not.

3.5 Initial ideology and vote choice in the structural model

Consumer-voter i in county j has initial ideology

$$r_{ij0} = \delta_j + \beta^V d_i + \varepsilon_{ij}. \quad (4)$$

Objects.

- δ_j is a county intercept chosen to match pre-Fox county voting patterns.
- d_i is a vector of demographics.
- ε_{ij} is an idiosyncratic ideology shock.

At election time, the voter supports the Republican candidate if her ideology is to the right of the election-specific cutpoint:

$$\text{Vote Republican}_{it} = 1\{r_{it} \geq P_t\}, \quad t \in \{2000, 2004, 2008\}. \quad (5)$$

Interpretation. The cutpoint P_t captures national election-year conditions that shift the aggregate Republican vote share.

3.6 Viewership time allocation

Given access to the set of news channels C_{jt} in package j , consumer-voter i allocates time to maximize

$$v_{ij} = \sum_{c \in C_{jt}} \gamma_{ict} \log(1 + T_{ijc}), \quad (6)$$

subject to a weekly time budget.

Objects.

- T_{ijc} is time spent watching channel c .
- γ_{ict} is the consumer's preference intensity for channel c .
- The outside option is all non-cable-news time.

Interpretation. Time spent on news is a choice. Higher channel preference generates more viewing, but the logarithmic form imposes diminishing marginal utility from watching additional time.

3.7 Taste for like-minded news

The channel preference component is modeled as

$$\gamma_{it} = \chi_{it} \circ \nu_{it}, \quad (7)$$

$$\chi_{ict} \sim \text{Bernoulli} \left(\alpha_{0ct} + \Pi_{0c} d_i + \zeta_0 \text{pos}_{ict} - \eta ((a + br_{ct}) - r_{it})^2 \right), \quad (8)$$

$$\nu_{ict} \sim \text{Exp} (\alpha_{ct} + \Pi_c d_i + \zeta \text{pos}_{ict}). \quad (9)$$

Objects.

- χ_{ict} determines whether consumer i has positive taste for channel c .
- ν_{ict} determines the intensity of preference if taste is positive.
- r_{ct} is the text-based ideology estimate for channel c in year t .
- $a + br_{ct}$ scales perceived channel ideology.
- η governs taste for like-minded news.

Interpretation. If $\eta > 0$, ideological distance lowers the probability that a viewer watches a channel. This is the model's selective-exposure mechanism.

3.8 Ideological influence

After watching cable news, ideology evolves according to

$$r_{it} = \frac{r_{i,t-1} + \rho \sum_c T_{ic,t-1} (a + br_{c,t-1})}{1 + \rho \sum_c T_{ic,t-1}} + \xi_{it}. \quad (10)$$

Objects.

- ρ is the persuasion or influence parameter.
- $T_{ic,t-1}$ is time spent watching channel c in the previous period.
- $a + br_{c,t-1}$ is the perceived ideology of channel c .
- ξ_{it} is a random ideology shock.

Interpretation. A viewer's ideology is pulled toward the ideology of the channels she watches. The more time she watches, the stronger the pull. With $\rho > 0$ and $\eta > 0$, the model can generate a feedback loop: viewers watch like-minded news, become more aligned with it, and then find it even more attractive.

3.9 Estimation by indirect inference

The model is estimated by simulated indirect inference. The authors choose structural parameters so that simulated data reproduce the regression patterns observed in the real data.

The auxiliary moments include:

- first-stage regressions of viewership on channel positions and demographics;
- linear probability models for watching any positive amount of each channel;
- IV regressions of voting on predicted Fox News viewership;
- OLS regressions of voting on cable news viewership;
- aggregate vote shares and average viewership moments by year.

Interpretation. The structural model is disciplined by the same variation that identifies the IV estimates, plus auxiliary moments that help separate selection into like-minded news from persuasion.

4 Identification and instruments: what makes the estimates credible

4.1 Instrument relevance

The instrument is relevant because lower channel positions increase viewership. The preferred first-stage coefficient for FNC position is negative and precisely estimated. A one-standard-deviation improvement in Fox News position increases average Fox News viewing by about 2.5 minutes per week.

Economic intuition. Channel position affects browsing and attention costs. A viewer is more likely to encounter a channel if it is closer to the beginning of the lineup or closer to other commonly watched channels.

4.2 Exclusion restriction

The key exclusion restriction is that local Fox News channel position affects Republican vote share only through Fox News exposure, not through unobserved local political preferences.

Main threat. Cable companies might put Fox News in lower positions in areas with stronger conservative demand. If this were true, channel position would proxy for preexisting Republican ideology rather than exogenous exposure.

4.3 Evidence supporting the exclusion restriction

The paper provides several checks.

Predicted viewership. Areas whose demographics predict high Fox News viewership do not systematically place Fox News in lower channel positions.

Predicted voting. Areas whose demographics predict higher Republican voting do not systematically place Fox News in lower channel positions.

Pre-Fox politics. Fox News channel position does not predict 1996 Republican vote share or 1996 Republican campaign contribution share.

Satellite placebo. Local cable position predicts cable-subscriber Fox News viewership but does not predict same-zip satellite-subscriber Fox News viewership.

Interpretation. These tests do not prove the instrument is perfect, but they strongly reduce the concern that channel positions were targeted to local political tastes.

4.4 Fixed effects and controls

The main specifications include state-year or county-year fixed effects, channel availability controls, cable-system controls, and rich demographics.

Interpretation. Fixed effects absorb broad geographic and time-varying political patterns. Demographics and pre-treatment political variables absorb observable sorting. The remaining identifying variation is within similar areas that differ in where Fox News appears in the local cable lineup.

4.5 LATE interpretation

The IV estimate is not the average effect of Fox News on all viewers. It is a local average treatment effect for viewers whose Fox News consumption changes because of channel position.

Interpretation. These compliers may be relatively moderate or less attached to a fixed channel choice. That helps explain why IV estimates are larger than OLS estimates: marginal viewers may be more persuadable than viewers who choose Fox News regardless of position.

4.6 Structural identification

The structural model uses multiple moments to separate mechanisms.

Persuasion ρ . Mainly disciplined by the IV relationship between predicted Fox News viewing and voting.

Taste for like-minded news η . Disciplined by the difference between OLS correlations and IV estimates, plus audience composition and viewership patterns.

Channel ideology scale a, b . Disciplined by how the text-based slant measures relate to observed political and viewership behavior.

Interpretation. The structural model's conclusions are stronger but more assumption-dependent than the reduced-form IV results.

4.7 Limitations

Important limitations remain:

- channel position could still correlate with unobserved factors not captured by the placebo tests;
- the IV effect applies to marginal viewers induced by channel position;
- the structural model assumes symmetric persuasion toward channel ideology and does not model backlash;
- text-based slant measures may miss visual framing, tone, guest selection, and issue emphasis;
- the model focuses on presidential voting, not turnout, congressional voting, or long-run political identity beyond the sample.

5 Tables and figures

5.1 Figure 1: channel positions and viewership

Read:

- Panel A plots residual minutes watched against ordinal channel position.
- The slope is negative: channels placed lower in the lineup receive more viewership.
- Panel B shows where CNN, FNC, and MSNBC are distributed in the channel lineup.

Economic message. Channel position is a powerful demand shifter. It changes viewership without directly changing news content.

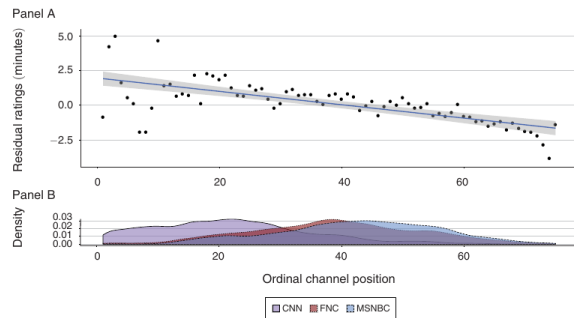


FIGURE 1. CHANNEL POSITIONS AND VIEWERSHIP

Notes: Panel A shows the relationship between the residual component of minutes watched and channel position, in a set of 34 comparable cable channels whose median positions across cable system-years are between 30 and 60 and thus typically occupy similar positions to FNC and MSNBC. Residuals are constructed by regressing minutes watched per week (in the Mediamark individual-level dataset) on the full set of individual demographics plus state-year fixed effects. The predicting regressions are estimated separately for each channel, such that demographic effects and state-specific time trends are allowed to vary by channel. The points in the figure are averages of these residual minutes across all channels located at a given ordinal position. The line is the least-squares fit. Panel B

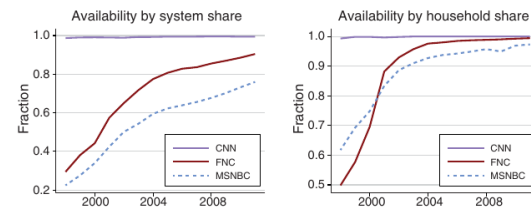


FIGURE 2. AVAILABILITY OF CABLE NEWS CHANNELS BY YEAR

55: Availability of cable news channels by year. The left panel lines represent the fraction of cable systems which carry the news channels. The right panel lines represent the fraction of cable subscribers for whom the news channels are carried on their system.

5.2 Figure 2: availability of cable news channels

Read:

- CNN is almost universally available throughout the sample.
- Fox News and MSNBC expand rapidly after entry.
- By the early 2000s, availability variation becomes limited.

Economic message. Availability-based identification is most useful around entry. Channel-position variation remains useful after availability becomes widespread.

5.3 Figure 3: estimated channel ideology

Read:

- Fox News is consistently more conservative than CNN and MSNBC.
- MSNBC initially looks similar to CNN but moves left after the mid-2000s.
- The dispersion in channel slant grows over time.

Economic message. Cable news does not only affect politics through more viewing; the ideological content of the channels also changes over time.

5.4 Table 2: first-stage regressions

Read:

- The coefficient on FNC position is negative across specifications.

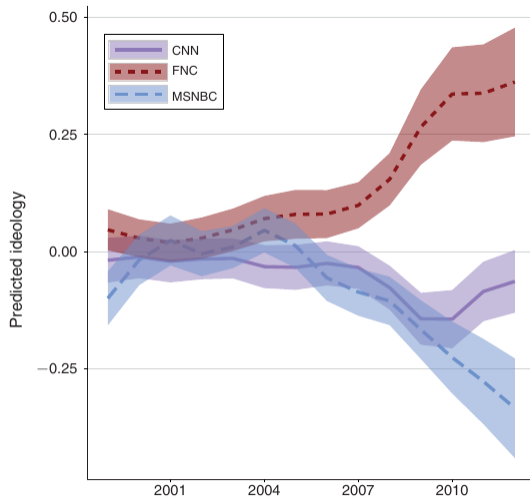


FIGURE 3. ESTIMATED IDEOLOGY BY CHANNEL YEAR

TABLE 2—FIRST-STAGE REGRESSIONS: NIELSEN DATA

	FNC minutes per week					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
FNC position	-0.146 (0.043)	-0.075 (0.039)	-0.174 (0.028)	-0.167 (0.025)	-0.097 (0.033)	-0.111 (0.030)
MSNBC position	0.078 (0.036)	0.073 (0.032)	0.064 (0.025)	0.070 (0.022)	0.019 (0.034)	0.020 (0.035)
Has MSNBC only	1.904 (3.697)	1.137 (3.713)	-3.954 (4.255)	-2.804 (3.416)	-1.220 (6.180)	-1.562 (5.397)
Has FNC only	31.423 (2.677)	26.526 (2.546)	23.460 (2.278)	22.011 (1.864)	15.141 (2.697)	15.069 (2.314)
Has both	24.859 (2.919)	23.118 (2.687)	18.338 (2.361)	16.168 (1.991)	15.159 (3.216)	14.486 (2.842)
Satellite FNC minutes				0.197 (0.013)		0.173 (0.015)
Fixed effects	Year	State-year	State-year	State-year	County-year	County-year
Cable controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Demographics	None	None	Extended	Extended	Extended	Extended
Robust F -stat	11.39	3.72	39.02	44.7	8.86	13.43
Number of clusters	5,789	5,789	4,830	4,761	4,839	4,770
Observations	71,150	71,150	59,541	52,053	59,684	52,165
R^2	0.030	0.074	0.213	0.377	0.428	0.544

Notes: Cluster-robust standard errors in parentheses (clustered by cable system). Instrument is the ordinal position of FNC on the local system. The omitted category for the availability dummies is systems where neither FNC nor MSNBC are available. In columns 4 and 6, the specification conditions on the average FNC ratings among satellite subscribers in the same zip code. Cable system controls include the total number of channels on the system and the number of broadcast channels on the system, as well as an indicator for Nielsen collection mode (diary versus set-top). Basic demographics include the racial, gender, age, income, educational, and urban/rural makeup of the zip code. Extended demographics includes the Basic set plus information on the percentage of homeowners; median housing values, sizes, ages, and property tax rates; the fraction of the population receiving food stamps; median social security income; the fraction of veterans; the fractions of married, unmarried, and same-sex couples; the share of federal campaign contributions that went to Republican candidates in 1996; the Republican presidential share of the county in 1996; and the religious composition of the county. Observations are weighted by the number of survey individuals in the zip code according to Nielsen.

- In the preferred state-year specification with extended demographics, the coefficient is about -0.174 minutes per week per channel position.
- The first-stage F -statistic is strong in the preferred specification.
- Adding same-zip satellite Fox News minutes barely changes the cable-position coefficient.

Economic message. Channel position shifts Fox News consumption in a statistically and economically meaningful way.

5.5 Table 4: second-stage voting effects

Read:

- Predicted Fox News minutes are positively related to McCain vote share in 2008.
- The preferred state-fixed-effect estimate with satellite controls implies roughly 7.2 percentage points for one additional hour per week.
- The instrument-induced change is much smaller than one hour, about 2.5 minutes per week for a one-standard-deviation position change.
- This translates to about 0.3 percentage points in Republican vote share.

Economic message. The persuasion effect is large per hour, but the natural variation in viewing generated by channel position is small.

5.6 Table 5: cable-position placebo tests

Read:

- Fox News position is not lower in places predicted to watch more Fox News.
- Fox News position is not lower in places predicted to vote more Republican.

TABLE 4—SECOND STAGE REGRESSIONS: ZIP CODE VOTING DATA

	2008 McCain vote percentage			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Predicted FNC minutes	0.152 (0.056, 0.277)	0.120 (0.005, 0.248)	0.157 (-0.126, 0.938)	0.098 (-0.121, 0.429)
Satellite FNC minutes		-0.021 (-0.047, 0.001)		-0.015 (-0.073, 0.022)
Fixed effects	State	State	County	County
Cable system controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Demographics	Extended	Extended	Extended	Extended
Number of clusters	4,814	3,993	4,729	4,001
Observations	17,400	12,417	17,283	12,443
R ²	0.833	0.841	0.907	0.919

Notes: The first stage is estimated using viewership data for all Nielsen TV households. See first-stage tables for description of instruments and control variables. Observations in the first stage are weighted by the number of survey individuals in the zip code according to Nielsen. Confidence intervals are generated from 1,000 independent STID-block-bootstraps of the first and second stage datasets. Reported lower and upper bounds give the central 95 percent interval of the relevant bootstrapped statistic.

TABLE 5—FNC CABLE POSITION PLACEBO TESTS

	Predicted viewing		Predicted voting		1996 contributions		1996 vote
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
FNC position	0.100 (0.034)	0.033 (0.026)	0.027 (0.022)	-0.0004 (0.017)	0.0002 (0.0002)	0.001 (0.0003)	-0.006 (0.012)
Fixed effects	State-year	County-year	State-year	County-year	State-year	County-year	State-year
Demographics	Extended	Extended	Extended	Extended	Extended	Extended	Extended
Number of clusters	4,830	4,839	4,814	4,827	4,830	4,839	4,830
Observations	59,551	59,694	17,400	17,451	59,551	59,694	59,551
R ²	0.380	0.827	0.339	0.729	0.176	0.436	0.571

Notes: Cluster-robust standard errors in parentheses (clustered by cable system). Columns 1–4 regress predicted-from-demographics hours of FNC and predicted-from-demographics Republican vote share, respectively, on FNC cable position. The predicting regressions exclude FNC position but include the indicated set of demographic controls. Columns 5–7 regress indicators of pretreatment political attitudes (1996 county-level Republican presidential vote share and 1996 zip code level Republican campaign contribution share) on FNC cable position. 1996 vote data is defined at the county level, and thus there is no specification with county-state-year fixed effects for this dependent variable.

- Fox News position does not predict 1996 Republican contributions or 1996 Republican vote share.

Economic message. The local positioning of Fox News does not appear to be targeted toward already-Republican areas.

5.7 Table 6: satellite placebo first stage

Read:

- The interaction of FNC position with cable subscription is negative.
- The interaction of FNC position with satellite subscription is small and statistically weak.
- The placebo rejects the idea that local cable position simply captures local demand for Fox News.

Economic message. The same local political environment does not generate the same channel-position effect when viewers do not face the local cable lineup.

TABLE 6—SATELLITE PLACEBO FIRST STAGE: NIELSEN DATA

	FNC minutes per week			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
FNC position × cable	-0.155 (0.043)	-0.264 (0.035)	-0.151 (0.048)	-0.219 (0.051)
FNC position × sat	0.031 (0.049)	-0.050 (0.041)	0.037 (0.063)	0.045 (0.067)
MSNBC position × cable	0.102 (0.036)	0.092 (0.032)	0.035 (0.049)	0.046 (0.048)
MSNBC position × sat	-0.004 (0.040)	-0.029 (0.033)	-0.029 (0.072)	-0.033 (0.074)
Fixed effects	State-year	State-year	County-year	County-year
Cable controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Demographics	None	Extensive	None	Extensive
Chow test <i>p</i> -value	0	0	0.011	0.001
Number of clusters	5,786	4,830	5,786	4,830
Observations	127,072	107,829	127,072	107,829
R ²	0.032	0.077	0.232	0.278

Notes: Cluster-robust standard errors in parentheses (clustered by cable system). Positions are the ordinal position of FNC/MSNBC on the local cable system. The omitted category for the availability dummies is systems where neither FNC nor MSNBC is available. Cable system controls include the total number of channels on the system and the number of broadcast channels on the system. All controls (including fixed effects) are interacted with a dummy for the observation corresponding to satellite viewership. Observations are weighted by the number of survey individuals in the zip code according to Nielsen.

TABLE 7—KEY PARAMETER ESTIMATES

Parameter	Estimate	Bootstrapped standard error
Slant preference (η)	0.02473	0.0064
Ideological influence (ρ)	0.05244	0.0147
Position effect—ratings	-0.00020	0.00008
Position effect—viewership	-0.00039	0.00094
2000 R/D threshold	-0.31354	0.0368
2004 R/D threshold	0.06380	0.1421
2008 R/D threshold	0.12089	0.0398
Channel ideology intercept (<i>a</i>)	0.32259	0.0311
Channel ideology slope (<i>b</i>)	17.27089	0.0132

Note: Standard errors clustered by cable system and computed by block bootstrap.

his distance implies that an average demographic voter located at the ideological

5.8 Table 7: key structural parameters

Read:

- The slant-preference parameter η is positive.

- The ideological-influence parameter ρ is positive.
- The estimated ideology scale greatly amplifies the raw text-based slant measures.
- An hour per week of watching a channel for a year moves a viewer just over 5 percent of the distance toward that channel's ideology.

Economic message. Both selective exposure and persuasion are present. Their interaction is what makes polarization possible.

5.9 Figure 4: partisan composition of audiences

Read:

- The model predicts increasing partisan sorting of audiences over time.
- Fox News viewers become more Republican; MSNBC viewers become more Democratic.
- The simulated pattern resembles the external Pew audience data.

Economic message. The model does not assume perfect audience segregation; rather, segregation emerges gradually through tastes and influence.

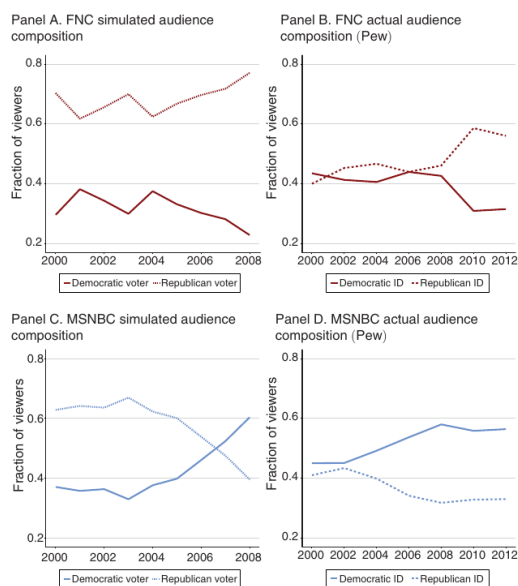


FIGURE 4. PARTISAN COMPOSITION OF VIEWERSHIP OVER TIME

Notes: Panels A and C show the partisan composition of the audience of FNC and MSNBC over time in our simulation.

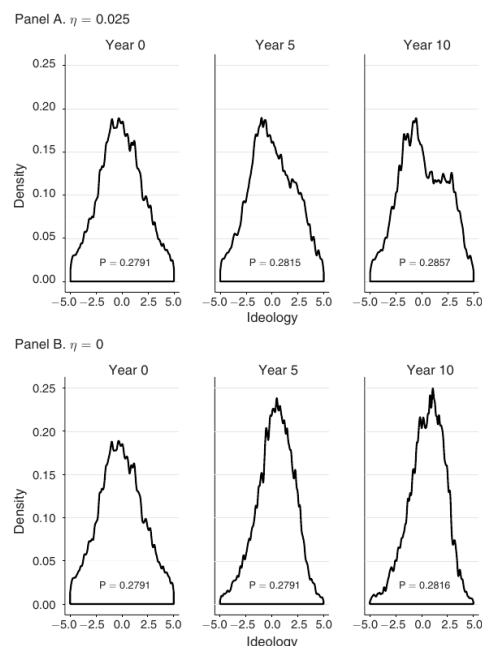


FIGURE 5. EVOLUTION OF IDEOLOGY DISTRIBUTIONS

5.10 Figure 5: polarization dynamics

Read:

- With $\eta > 0$, the ideology distribution becomes more bimodal over time.
- The Esteban-Ray polarization measure rises from about 0.279 to about 0.286 over ten years.
- With $\eta = 0$, the distribution remains much less polarized.

Economic message. Persuasion alone does not necessarily produce polarization. Polarization requires selective exposure interacting with persuasion.

5.11 Table 10: election counterfactuals

Read:

- Eliminating Fox News reduces Republican vote share by 0.46 points in 2000.
- The estimated Fox News effect grows to 3.59 points in 2004 and 6.34 points in 2008.
- Making MSNBC track CNN has a much smaller electoral effect.

Economic message. Fox News’s political impact grows because its audience grows and because the channel becomes more conservative.

TABLE 10—EFFECTS OF TWO COUNTERFACTUAL SCENARIOS

Election	R vote share change	
	No Fox News	MSNBC tracks CNN
2000	−0.0046	0.0006
2004	−0.0359	−0.0124
2008	−0.0634	−0.0009

Notes: In the first, Fox News is eliminated from cable lineups. Column 2 shows the change in the Republican vote share of the presidential popular vote in the no-Fox scenario relative to the baseline. In the second, MSNBC’s ideological positioning matches that of CNN throughout the 2000–2008 period. Column 3 shows the change in the Republican vote share of the presidential popular vote in the MSNBC-matching-CNN scenario relative to the baseline.

TABLE 11—MEDIA POWER

Election	Potential vote share swing			
	CNN	FNC	MSNBC	Monopolist
2000	0.0316	0.0126	0.0082	0.0465
2004	0.1456	0.0955	0.0409	0.2123
2008	0.1862	0.1568	0.0563	0.2893

Notes: The maximum potential vote share swing that the channel could engineer, by election. The monopolist column is the maximum vote share swing attainable if all three channels were controlled by a single owner.

5.12 Table 11: media power

Read:

- CNN has high potential media power because of its large and broad audience.
- FNC’s potential influence rises sharply over time.
- A hypothetical monopolist controlling all three cable news channels could generate a much larger vote-share swing.

Economic message. Media ownership matters because control over editorial slant can translate into electoral influence.

5.13 Figure 6: optimal slant under different objectives

Read:

- Ratings-maximizing slants are more centrist.
- Fox News’s observed slant is closer to the Republican vote-share-maximizing slant.
- Moving further right would eventually reduce Fox News’s influence by losing too many moderate or liberal viewers.

Economic message. The trade-off between audience size and ideological intensity shapes the political power of media outlets.

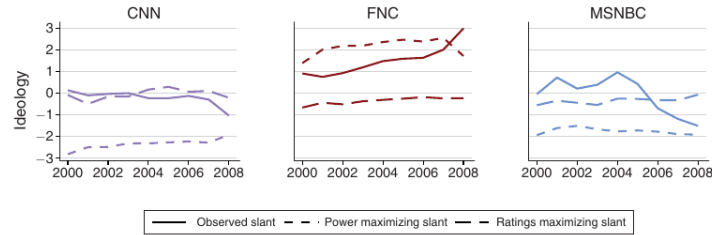


FIGURE 6. OPTIMAL SLANT UNDER DIFFERENT OBJECTIVES

Notes: Channels' ideological positioning from 2000–2008. The three lines are the observed position from the text-based measure, the position that would maximize the channel's ratings, and the position that maximizes the vote share for a favored party. For FNC, we show the position that maximizes Republican vote share; for the other two channels we show the position that maximizes Democratic vote share.

The optimal ideological location from a ratings perspective is quite centrist, and

6 Short summary

- The paper estimates the persuasive effect of slanted cable news and viewers' taste for like-minded news.
- The main instrument is cable channel position: lower positions make channels easier to watch.
- Fox News position strongly predicts Fox News viewership.
- Fox News viewership induced by channel position increases Republican presidential vote share.
- Placebo tests show that Fox News position is not correlated with predicted Republican taste, pre-Fox Republican voting, or same-zip satellite Fox News viewing.
- The structural model estimates both positive persuasion and positive selective exposure.
- Removing Fox News has increasingly large estimated effects on Republican vote share from 2000 to 2008.
- Cable news can generate a modest increase in public polarization, mainly because persuasion interacts with taste for like-minded news.
- Media power can be large, especially under concentrated ownership, but influence-maximizing slant can differ from viewership-maximizing slant.

7 Conclusion

7.1 Core conclusion: what the paper establishes

Martin and Yurukoglu show that slanted cable news can causally affect voting behavior. Their channel-position instrument shifts news exposure, and induced Fox News viewing raises Republican presidential vote share. The paper also shows that viewers prefer ideologically congenial news and that this selective exposure can interact with persuasion to generate polarization.

7.2 Economic intuition

Cable news affects politics through two connected margins. First, channel placement changes the cost of discovering and watching a channel. Second, once viewers watch slanted news, their ideology

can move toward that outlet. When viewers also prefer news close to their own ideology, this creates a reinforcing loop: exposure changes ideology, and ideology changes future exposure.

7.3 Takeaway

The central takeaway is that media slant is economically and politically consequential. Cable news is not only a product market where consumers choose preferred content; it is also a political influence technology. The design of media markets, ownership structure, and distribution rules can therefore affect electoral outcomes and polarization.